

Thoughts on Current Society

Yesterday, I saw a post about a group of graduates walking out on a tech CEO mid-speech. I don't know enough about what motivated them to say whether the walkout itself was right or wrong. But watching it, and the reaction to it, sparked a longer thought I've been circling for a while: society has found a scapegoat for its failures, and that scapegoat is AI.

The pattern shows up everywhere. Social media is blamed for a mental health crisis in the youth. Tech billionaires are blamed for the state of the world. AI is blamed for whatever is going wrong this month. I don't think any of this is entirely false. But I think it's incomplete in a way that matters, and the incompleteness is doing real damage to how we think about solutions.

Take the claim that social media has caused mass depression in young people. The mechanism people point to is comparison, endless exposure to unrealistic bodies, beauty standards, curated lifestyles. It's a real mechanism. But it isn't a new one. Anyone who grew up on television and film absorbed the same unrealistic standards, arguably worse ones, with far less diversity represented than exists now. What's genuinely different is exposure: television was a few hours a day, a phone is every waking moment. So the honest version of the claim isn't "social media invented this harm," it's "technology took an old harm and made it inescapable."

The easy answer is "just log off." But I don't think that's a fair thing to say to someone who was born into a world where a phone is simply where people are. Asking a teenager to log off is asking them to opt out of their social world entirely. So who's actually responsible for that bind, the platforms, the parents, society at large? I don't think there's a single answer, and I think the search for a single answer is itself part of the problem.

This is where I keep landing: most of what gets blamed on new technology is really an old, long-standing problem reaching a point where it can no longer be ignored. History is full of manipulated news, polarized politics, and manufactured outrage, none of that started with a feed. What AI and social media have done is act as an accelerant and a mirror. They speed up existing dynamics and reflect them back at a scale and speed we've never had to metabolize before. That's a real and serious problem. It's just a different problem than "AI broke society," and treating it as the same thing means we keep aiming at the wrong target.

Once I follow that thread, it gets harder to locate a single villain. Is it government? Capitalism? Our parents, and their parents before them? Is it human nature? At some point I stop asking who's to blame and start asking a more useful question: why do so many of us fail to fix what we know is broken, even at the smallest scale, in our own relationships and our own lives? I don't think it's usually deliberate. I think it's often that fixing things is harder than living with them, and when survival or just exhaustion is in the mix, the line between right and wrong gets blurry fast.

That leads somewhere uncomfortable: how much free will do we actually have, if the mental models we use to make decisions were largely inherited from parents, from a culture we didn't choose, from a world already in motion before we arrived? I don't think this excuses individual behavior. But it does mean the individual is the smallest unit in a much larger system, and systems are hard to blame in the way we blame people. Maybe society, the whole human race, is best understood as an emergent system one where causes are distributed so widely that finding a single point of failure is close to impossible.

I understand why that conclusion is tempting to stop at. I've been in enough conversations that end with "there's nothing I can do about it, it is what it is." I don't judge anyone for landing there, the scale of the problem is genuinely overwhelming, and it's exhausting to think about for very long. But I think that's exactly why things don't change: not because people don't care, but because the size of the problem has worn down the will to engage with it at all.

Which brings me back to the walkout. I said earlier I don't know enough about their specific reasoning to judge it, and I mean that. But sitting with it longer, I think what I originally read as "misguided blame" might actually just be a group of people standing up for themselves in the only way available to them at that moment, at a small scale. That's worth more respect than my first reaction gave it. Where I'd still push back is on the broader cultural habit the walkout gets swept into, the idea that any one company or technology is sufficient explanation for where we are. Technology, including AI, is one of the great achievements of human progress, and it continues to show us what people are capable of building. It's also, right now, tipping toward being cast as the villain of a story that's really much older than it is. I see far too few conversations correcting that in people's minds, and far too many amplifying conspiracy, fear, and the sense that everything is collapsing when it mostly isn't.

So where does this leave me? I don't have a clean answer, and I'd rather say that honestly than manufacture one. What I want to believe and am still working out how to argue for, is that technological advancement and human wellbeing aren't actually a trade-off. I don't think we have to slow down progress to protect people, and I don't think protecting people has to mean treating technology as the enemy. I think we can build a world where both succeed. But that takes collective will, and collective will is exactly what erodes when everyone quietly agrees there's nothing to be done. I do believe we're capable of new solutions to old problems, new ways of living, given everything we now know. I just think we have to stop looking for someone to blame long enough to start looking for what to build.